Recommend Her

HOW TO OPTIMIZE YOUR CV FOR SPONSORSHIP

A COMPREHENSIVE GUIDE TO CRAFTING A CV THAT GETS NOTICED BY LEADERS WHO RECOMMEND

INTRODUCTION: The Shift from Application to Sponsorship

Most CVs are written for one purpose: to pass through an Applicant Tracking System (ATS) and land an interview. But **Recommend Her** operates differently. Your CV here isn't just for hiring managers—it's for **sponsors**. Leaders who will carry your name into rooms you cannot enter.

This requires a different kind of CV. One that tells not just what you've done, but who you are becoming. One that makes it easy for a sponsor to say:

"I know someone perfect for this."

This guide will walk you through exactly how to craft that CV.

SECTION 1: The Sponsorship Mindset

Before you write a single word, understand how sponsors read differently than recruiters.

Recruiters Look For	Sponsors Look For
Keywords matching a job description	Leadership potential and trajectory
Years of experience	Impact and influence
Gaps in employment	Readiness for the next level
Technical skills	Judgment and decision-making
Job stability	Ambition and hunger

Your Goal: Create a CV that a busy leader can scan in 60 seconds and immediately understand:

- Who you are
- What you're capable of
- Where you're going
- Why you're ready for sponsorship

SECTION 2: The Visibility Formula

Every section of your CV should answer one question: **"What makes this woman unforgettable?"**

Use this formula for every role you list:

[Action Verb] + [What You Did] + [How You Did It] + [Measurable Impact]

WEAK

Managed a team of five and handled budgets.

SPONSOR-READY

Led a cross-functional team of five to launch a new product line, managing a $500K budget and delivering 15% above projected revenue in first year.

WEAK

Responsible for client relationships.

SPONSOR-READY

Cultivated relationships with 20+ enterprise clients, achieving 98% retention rate and securing $2M in contract renewals.

SECTION 3: The 5 Essential Elements of a Sponsor-Ready CV

Element 1: The Powerful Headline

Beneath your name, include a professional headline that captures your value proposition—not just your job title.

INSTEAD OF

Marketing Manager

WRITE

Marketing Leader | Brand Strategist | Driving Growth

Through Storytelling

INSTEAD OF

Project Coordinator

WRITE

Project Coordinator | Operations Optimizer | Delivering Results Under Pressure

Element 2: The Impact Summary (Not an Objective)

Replace the outdated "Objective" statement with a 3-4 line summary that tells your story.

Template:
[Experienced/Seasoned/Emerging] [Your Field] professional with [X] years of experience in [Key Area 1] and [Key Area 2]. Proven track record of [Major Achievement Type]. Passionate about [What Drives You] and ready to [Your Next Step Goal].

Example:
Seasoned finance professional with 8 years of experience in investment analysis and portfolio management. Proven track record of identifying high-growth opportunities that delivered 20%+ returns. Passionate about driving strategic financial decisions and ready to transition into a senior leadership role.

Element 3: Achievement-Focused Experience

For each role, include 3-5 bullet points following the Visibility Formula. Lead every bullet with a strong action verb.

Leadership	Results	Innovation	Strategy
Led	Increased	Created	Developed
Directed	Delivered	Designed	Formulated
Managed	Generated	Implemented	Executed
Championed	Exceeded	Launched	Orchestrated
Mentored	Achieved	Pioneered	Aligned

Element 4: The "Ready for More" Section

Sponsors want to know you're not just good at your current job—you're ready for the next one. Include a section titled **"Leadership & Initiative Highlights"** or **"Beyond the Role."**

- Special projects you led
- Committees you served on
- Initiatives you started
- Mentorship you provided
- Training you completed

Element 5: Skills That Signal Readiness

Include both **hard skills** (technical competencies) and **soft skills** (leadership competencies). Group them logically.

Technical Skills	Leadership Skills
Financial Modeling	Strategic Planning
Salesforce CRM	Cross-functional Collaboration
Data Analytics (Tableau)	Team Development

Technical Skills	Leadership Skills
Project Management	Stakeholder Management
Digital Marketing	Change Management

SECTION 4: What to Leave Out

A sponsor-ready CV is focused and intentional. Remove:

- ❌ Outdated roles (over 10-15 years ago, unless highly relevant)
- ❌ Personal information (photo, age, marital status)
- ❌ Generic hobbies ("reading," "traveling") unless they demonstrate something unique
- ❌ Unnecessary jargon and buzzwords
- ❌ Responsibilities without results

SECTION 5: Formatting for Fast Reading

Sponsors are busy. Your CV must be scannable in seconds.

DO

✓ Use clear section headings
✓ Keep to 2 pages maximum (1 page for early career)
✓ Use bullet points, not paragraphs
✓ Include plenty of white space
✓ Save as PDF with your name: `Wahda_Mbaraka_CV.pdf`

DON'T

✗ Use dense paragraphs
✗ Get creative with fonts or colors (keep it professional)
✗ Include tables or graphics that might not render properly
✗ Forget to proofread (one typo can undermine credibility)

SECTION 6: The "Sponsor Lens" Checklist

Before submitting your CV to **Recommend Her**, review it through the sponsor's eyes:

- [ ] Can a leader understand my career trajectory in under 60 seconds?
- [ ] Does each bullet point show impact, not just activity?
- [ ] Have I quantified results wherever possible?
- [ ] Does my summary convey who I am and where I'm going?
- [ ] Have I demonstrated readiness for the next level?
- [ ] Is my CV free of errors and professionally formatted?
- [ ] Would I feel proud to have a leader share this on my behalf?

SECTION 7: Real Example Transformations

Example 1: Task vs. Result

BEFORE: TASK-FOCUSED

Responsible for social media accounts. Created content. Reported on engagement.

AFTER: SPONSOR-READY

Led social media strategy across four platforms, growing follower engagement by 45% year-over-year through data-driven content planning and community management. Presented

quarterly insights to senior leadership.

Example 2: Summary Transformation

BEFORE: GENERIC SUMMARY

Hardworking professional seeking new opportunities in marketing.

AFTER: IMPACT SUMMARY

Digital marketing specialist with 6 years of experience driving brand awareness and customer acquisition. Proven track record of developing campaigns that increased revenue by 30%+ year-over-year. Ready to apply strategic marketing expertise in a senior role with greater leadership responsibility.

SECTION 8: Your CV Is Your Story—Own It

The most sponsor-ready CVs share one thing: **confidence without arrogance.**

Don't minimize your achievements. Don't use tentative language ("assisted with," "helped to," "supported"). Own your contributions fully and proudly.

WEAK LANGUAGE

Was involved in the project
Supported the team with
Helped to achieve

STRONG LANGUAGE

Led the project
Collaborated with the team to
Contributed to achieving

FINAL THOUGHTS: From CV to Connection

Your CV is your introduction. But at **Recommend Her**, it's also your invitation.

When you submit your optimized CV to our talent pool, you're not just applying for a job. You're signaling:

I am ready. I am ambitious. I am worth recommending.

And to the sponsors in our network, that signal is everything.

Now, go update that CV. Your future sponsor is waiting.

Ready to Join the Talent Pool?

- ✅ Update your CV using this guide
- ✅ Visit recommendher.africa/submit
- ✅ Upload your profile
- ✅ Get seen by leaders ready to recommend you

#RecommendHer #SponsorshipReady #WomenInLeadership #CVOptimization

This guide is part of the Recommend Her Movement—building a pipeline of visible, ready, and recommended women leaders.